



Certification Reference Document & Presentation

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CYSC 1101: Cybersecurity Careers and Digital Portfolio
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September 22, 2025

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Certification Name and Description

The certification name is Certified Information Systems Security Professional (CISSP). The CISSP is a widely recognized certification for cybersecurity professionals. The certification is given by the International Information Systems Security Certification Consortium. The certification validates the expertise of a professional for their security practices and knowledge.

Great For

The CISSP is ideal for skilled cybersecurity professionals that wish to advance their cybersecurity career into leadership and management positions. Security Managers, Security, Consultants, Cybersecurity Engineers, and other high-level positions fall under leadership and managerial roles. The CISSP is also great for increasing the potential for an individual to earn and to increase their recognition in the network of the information security industry. This is not ideal for the entry-level as it requires multiple years of experience.

Experience Level

The CISSP certification is designed for experienced cybersecurity professionals, not for absolute beginners. To be certified, candidates must have at least five years of paid full-time experience across a minimum of two of the eight CISSP domains. An experience waiver of one year is available for those with a qualifying degree or an approved credential.

Alternatively, individuals earlier in their careers can take the exam and become an "Associate of ISC2," a status that grants up to six years to acquire the necessary experience. The exam's focus on applying judgment and making risk-based decisions, rather than just memorizing definitions, is why employers use the CISSP as a signal for professionals ready to lead an enterprise security program.

Prerequisites

To obtain the Certified Information Systems Security Professional (CISSP) credential, candidates must satisfy specific prerequisites centered on professional experience. While there are no prior certifications required to sit for the exam, individuals must possess a minimum of five years of cumulative, paid, full-time work experience across at least two of the eight CISSP domains. Upon passing the exam, this work history must be verified through an endorsement process to finalize the certification. This requirement ensures that all successful candidates have a substantial background in the field before being awarded the full credential.

Cost

The total cost of pursuing the CISSP certification involves several components, including the exam registration, potential preparation materials, and ongoing maintenance fees. The exam registration fee is approximately \$1033 CAD, though regional pricing may cause this to vary. Once certified, an annual maintenance fee of about \$186 CAD is required. This fee is first paid upon the approval of a candidate's certification application.

Optional but often necessary preparation materials can range from about \$138 CAD to \$552 CAD for self-study books and practice tests, up to a more comprehensive budget of around \$414 CAD to \$1241 CAD for a combination of books, video courses, and practice questions. For those preferring an intensive learning approach, premium boot camps can cost between \$2070 CAD and \$5521 CAD. A typical first-year budget, following a minimal path, would be around \$1432 CAD, which includes the exam fee, basic study materials, and the first annual maintenance fee, not accounting for any potential rescheduling fees of around \$69 CAD or retake costs.

Required CPEs

CISSP certified individuals are required to earn 120 Continuing Professional Education (CPE) credits every three years. Some of the activities to earn CPE credits involve attending ISC2 events and courses, conducting self-study, and more. These activities are divided into two categories; group A and group B. Group A activities are directly related to the 8 domains of CISSP while Group B are outside the CISSP domains yet improve general professional skills. It is recommended that CISSP holders earn 40 CPEs such that they can better hold their certification.

Expiration

To maintain an active CISSP credential, individuals must participate in a three-year cycle. 120 Continuing Professional Education (CPE) credits must be earned per cycle. In addition to earning CPEs, a \$186 CAD Annual Maintenance Fee (AMF) must be paid each year. Failure to complete these requirements within the cycle, including a 90-day grace period, can lead to a suspended certification and, in prolonged cases, termination, potentially requiring the individual to re-take the exam.

Included Exam Topics

There are eight main domains that are topics included in the CISSP exam. These domains are Security and Risk Management, Asset Security, Security Architecture and Engineering, Communication and Network Security, Identity and Access Management (IAM), Security Assessment and Testing, Security Operations, and Software Development Security.

Often Required For

CISSP is often required for cybersecurity roles in the mid to senior level. Examples of these roles are Chief Information Security Officers and Directors of Security. Senior management roles like these often require CISSP to validate their expertise in implementing effective security principles and knowledge to perform well in such positions.

Helpful Resources to Prepare

There are many effective resources for students preparing for the CISSP exam. The ISC2 CISSP Official Study Guide and its companion Official Practice Tests provide a structured approach to the material and exam questions. It is recommended to anchor all study efforts to the official CISSP Exam Outline and its eight domains to ensure the content is current.

For practice, platforms like Boson ExSim and Kaplan IT Training are widely recommended for their scenario-based questions and detailed explanations. Students can also choose a course that fits their learning style, whether it be the officially aligned ISC2 Authorized Training, the in-depth premium courses from SANS, or more cost-effective video courses available on platforms such as Udemy and Pluralsight. Additionally, engaging with online communities like the CISSP subreddit, TechExams, or local ISC2 chapters are further resources to help you prepare.